

trades. Before the days of the hotline, brokerage firms had runners who would rush to the trading floor to relay orders.

When one of our dealers quit, I was asked if I would be interested in taking his place. I agreed, taking care not to show my excitement. I knew my boss was testing me out. He liked employees who worked hard but was wary of the overenthusiastic types.

Initially, my job on the floor was to answer the hotline and convey the order details to the senior dealers who would be scouting around for good bargains. For one month I was assigned to a senior, and had to observe him as he negotiated deals with brokers and jobbers.

A jobber is a professional speculator, and buys and sells shares for himself. He does not have any clients. His business is to speculate on which way prices are moving and make a quick profit on it. He does not want to buy shares and keep them for the long term as investors do. But, to do business on the floor of the stock exchange, he needs to have a broker as a sponsor. He shares a part of his profit with the broker under a pre-decided agreement.

You could say that in a way he acts as an agent of the broker. If the jobber defaults on a deal, the broker is held responsible by the stock exchange. Brokers, therefore, choose jobbers with care. Jobbers were an important source of liquidity, and brokers would always deal through them.

In those days, there were 'counters' for individual stocks. Jobbers and brokers dealing in Reliance shares would gather at a certain spot, those dealing in Tata Iron and Steel shares at another spot, and so on. 'A' group shares, in which a buyer or seller could carry forward trades to the next settlement by paying an interest charge known as badla, were called *vaida*. 'B' group shares, which were not eligible for carry-forward, were called *rokda* (cash) since they had to be settled at the end of the fortnightly settlement cycle, either with the positions being squared off or with the shares being delivered.

There was a public address system on every floor of the stock exchange building, on which would be broadcast the prices of mostly A group stocks, and sometimes B group stocks if there were big moves on them, corporate results and other important company announcements. For a price, brokers could get an extension of that system so that they could hear the broadcast sitting in their offices. Brokerages wanting to save on costs would usually